PHP Comments, Constants, and Variables

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Comments

Comments describe your scripts – what it does and how it does

PHP has two forms of comments:

- **Single-line comments** begin with a double slash (//).

<?php // This is a single-line comment ?>

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Comments

- **Multi-line comments** begin with "/*" and end with "*/".

```
<?php
 /* This is a multi-line
comment.*/
?>
```

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Variables

- Variables are used to store information like text strings, numbers or arrays.

- In PHP all the variables begin with a dollar sign "$" and the value can be assigned using the "=" operator.

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Syntax

$var_name = “Value”;

- Variables can, but do not need, to be declared before assignment



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Variable Names

Rules for naming variables or identifiers are as follows:

- A variable name must start with a letter or an underscore "_".
- A variable name can only contain alpha-numeric characters and underscores (a-z, A-Z, 0-9, and _).

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Variable Names

- A variable name should not contain spaces. If a variable name is more than one word, it should be separated with an underscore ($my_string), or with capitalization ($myString).
- Variables are case sensitive.

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PHP Keywords

and	echo	list
as	else	new
break	empty	or
case	eval	print
class	exit	require
const	for	return
continue	foreach	switch
declare	function	use
default	global	var
die	if	while
do	include	

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Variable Variables

- In PHP, it is also possible to create so-called variable variables. That is a variable whose name is contained in another variable:

```
$name = ‘foo’;
$$name = ‘bar’;
echo $foo;
// Displays ‘bar’
```

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Variable Variables

- We used the special syntax $$name to indicate that we want the interpreter to use the contents of

  $name

to reference a new variable– thus creating the new variable $foo, which is then printed out normally.

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Variable Variables

```
$x = “Eric”;
$$x = “Seufert”; //$Eric = “Seufert”;
echo “$x ${$x}”;
//would produce the same output as, echo “$x $Eric”;
//which is: Eric Seufert
```

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Variable Variables

- The curly braces around the variable variable is the standard syntax for outputting variable variables.
- Omitting the curly braces would have resulted with the following output:

Eric $Eric

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Variable Variables

- A technique to variable variables can also be used to hold function names inside a variable:

```
function myFunc(){
        echo ‘myFunc’;
}

$f = ‘myFunc’;
$f(); // will call myFunc();
```

Note: Clearly, this technique should be used with as much care as variable variables, as the opportunities for mistakes and security issues it raises are quite significant.

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Variable Types

Variable Type	Explanation
Integer	Whole number
Double	Real number
String	String of characters
Boolean	True or false
Array	List of items
Object	Instance of a class

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Variable Type Strength

PHP is weakly typed:

- variables do not need to be assigned a type at the time they are declared.
- PHP variable is determined by the value the variable holds and the way in which it is used.

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Using Variables

```
<html>
    <head><title>Hello World Script</title></head>
    <body>
        <?php
                $salutation = "Hello World!";
                echo "<p>$salutation</p>";
        ?>
        <p>This is an HTML section</p>
        <?php
                echo "<p>$salutation again</p>";
        ?>
    </body>
</html>
```

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Using Variables

- Output:

Hello World!

This is an HTML section

Hello World! again

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Variable Scope

- A *variable's scope* determines the locations from which the variable can be accessed.

Scope	Explanation
superglobal	Superglobal variables are predefined arrays, including $_POST and $_GET. They are accessible from anywhere on the page.
global	Global variables are visible throughout the script in which they are declared. However they are not visible within the functions in the script unless they are re-declared within the function as a global variables.
function	Variables in the function scope are called local variables. Local variables are local to the function in which they are declared.

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Super Globals

$_GET	Variables passed into a page on the query string.
$_POST	Variables passed in to a page through a form using the post method.
$_COOKIE	Cookie variables.
$_FILES	Variables containing information about the uploaded file.
$_ENV	PHP Environment variable that returns the name of the host server.
$_REQUEST	Variable passed into page through forms using string and cookies.
$_SERVER	Server environment variable that returns the URL of the referring page.
$_SESSION	Session variables.

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Constants

- Are like variables except that, once assigned a value, they cannot be changed.
- Are created using the define() function and by convention (but not by rule) are in all uppercase letters.
- Can be accessed from anywhere on the page.

Syntax:

```
define('CONST_NAME',VALUE);
```

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```
<html>
    <html>
        <title>Constants</title>
    </html>
    <body>
    <?php
        echo "<b>Using define() Function</b><br>";
        define ("YEAR", "2010");
        define ("INDAY", "June 12th");
        echo "Philippine Independence Day is " . INDAY . "<br>";
        echo "We are in year " . YEAR . ".<br>";
echo "This server is running version " . "<b>" . PHP_VERSION . " of the PHP on the
    " . PHP_OS . ".</b><br><br>";
        echo "This is saved on " . __FILE__;
    ?>
    </body>
</html>
```

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